building jihadi networks in India at the time. Other indigenous operators were active too and much of the terrorist activity remained relatively uncoordinated. Indian prosecutors allege that Riyaz Shahbandri brought various operators from the atomized jihadi movement together for a retreat in the south Indian town of Bhatkal in 2004. A year later Sheikh, Shahbandri and another Indian jihadi entrepreneur named Abdul Subhan Qureshi, who also trained with Lashkar and was present at the retreat, are believed to have formed the Indian Mujahideen network. Indian officials assert Sheikh's cadres who had trained in Pakistan provided the manpower for attacks and that he acted as the IM's Mumbai-based leadership liaison to these operatives. Shahbandri's cell was responsible for procuring explosives and bomb components, while his brother Iqbal recruited operatives to provide specialized IT support. Qureshi recruited SIMI activists for logistical support.[101] In 2005 the Indian Mujahideen network announced its presence with a bomb attack against a Hindu temple in the north Indian city of Varanasi.[102]

Lashkar is suspected of playing a key role in planning or otherwise supporting a number of the bombing attacks launched by Indian militants. It is often difficult to ascertain Lashkar's precise role in these attacks because the group deliberately obscured its involvement. Sometimes Indian militants were acting at its behest, at other times they were acting semi-autonomously with the group's assistance. Two things are clear: first, the Indian jihadi movement remained motivated primarily by domestic grievances rather than by India-Pakistan dynamics; and second, that movement became far more lethal than it otherwise would have been without external support. However, just as Lashkar does not view itself as an instrument of the state, even though it often acts in this capacity, most Indian militants did not perceive themselves as proxies for either Lashkar or Pakistan. To quote Praveen Swami, a journalist and expert on Indian jihadi networks, the wave of bombings that took place during this decade was 'homegrown terrorism, watered and fertilized by Lashkar.'[103] In other words, the group was a force multiplier for Indian militancy, rather than a key driver of it. Further, while Lashkar was the chief external outfit providing support for Indian jihadism, it was not the only one. It is to the nature of this assistance that we now turn.